

REFERENCE

The Day Move

When you *do something risky or face something you fear*, name what you're afraid will happen if you fail or lose your nerve, then roll with an appropriate ability.

On a 10+, you do what you intended or you hold steady; describe what it looks like.

On a 7-9, the Keeper will tell you how your actions would leave you vulnerable, and you can choose to back down or go through with it. If you go through with it, the Keeper describes what it looks like.

On a 12+, you do what you intended or you hold steady, and the Keeper will tell you some extra benefit or advantage you receive. Describe what it looks like.

The Night Move

When you *do something risky or face something you fear*, name what you're afraid will happen if you fail or lose your nerve. The Keeper will tell you how it is worse than you fear. You can choose to back down or go through with it. If you go through with it, roll with an appropriate ability.

On a 10+, you do what you intended or you hold steady; describe what it looks like.

On a 7-9, you do what you intended or you hold steady, but there is a complication or cost; the Keeper describes what it looks like.

On a 12+, you do what you intended or you hold steady, and the Keeper will tell you some extra benefit or advantage you receive. Describe what it looks like.

The Cozy Move

When you *have an intimate moment with another Maven while one of you is engaged in your cozy activity*, you may each clear an appropriate Condition. If it's your cozy activity, you can also stumble on a Clue relevant to the active mystery. Tell the Keeper what it is. The Clue cannot conclusively solve the mystery by itself.

The Gold Crown Mysteries Move

Once per mystery, *when any Maven says "This reminds me of something that happened to Amanda Delacourt!"*, work with the other players to describe how something that is happening in the situation reminds the Mavens of an event from one of the Gold Crown Mysteries. At a minimum, you must provide the following information:

- The name of the Gold Crown Mystery in question (no repeats, please!).
- The problem or situation Amanda found herself in that is similar to what the Mavens are experiencing.
- How Amanda eventually overcame the problem or resolved the situation.

Then, take a 12+ to a single relevant roll OR state a fact about the current situation that the Keeper must incorporate.

Note: *Generally-speaking, this move can only be used once per mystery, per group.*

The Occult Move

When you *engage in an activity related to the supernatural or the occult for the first time*, imagine what your actions would look like as a move. Say what triggers the move and roll with Sensitivity.

On a hit, it works; work with the Keeper to write the move—it is now a move all Mavens can use for the rest of the game and your roll stands.

On a 7-9, you must also mark the Crown of the Void.

On a miss, it's not something the Mavens can ever do and you also mark the Crown of the Void.

Note: *The Keeper can require you to have a strong fictional justification for doing so before attempting to trigger this move.*

The Meddling Move

When you *search for a clue, conduct research, or otherwise gather information*, describe how you're doing so and roll with an appropriate ability.

On a hit, you find a Clue. The Keeper will tell you what it is.

On a 7-9, there's a complication—either with the Clue itself, or a complication you encounter while searching. The Keeper will tell you what the complication is.

On a 12+, you also find a Void Clue OR you learn something about the Dark Conspiracy in Brindlewood Bay (Keeper's choice).

Theorize

When the Mavens *have an open, freewheeling discussion about the solution to a mystery once they have gathered a number of Clues equal to at least half the mystery's Complexity (rounded up)*—and reach a consensus—roll plus the number of Clues incorporated into the theory or otherwise explained away, minus the mystery's Complexity.

On a 10+, it's the correct solution. The Keeper will present an opportunity to take down the culprit or otherwise save the day.

On a 7-9, it's the correct solution, but the Keeper will either add an unwelcome complication to the solution itself, or present a complicated or dangerous opportunity to take down the culprit or save the day.

On a 6-, the solution is incorrect, and the Keeper reacts.

On a 12+, a person involved in the Dark Conspiracy of Brindlewood Bay also reveals themselves to the Mavens.

Note: *It doesn't matter who rolls Theorize when the time comes. Additionally, Theorize cannot be taken with advantage or disadvantage, nor is it subject to the effects of other moves. The success tier can be increased by putting on a Crown, but only if every Maven does so.*

MAVEN MOVES

*No two Mavens can have the same Maven move at the start. Additionally, no two Mavens can have **Dale Cooper** and **Fox Mulder** at the same time, though a single Maven can acquire both during the course of the game.*

D.A. Daracus

Once per mystery, if you and/or any number of your fellow Mavens would suffer physical harm, you can describe how that physical harm is just narrowly avoided.

Frank Columbo

Something about you causes the elite of society to not take you too seriously. What is it? Once per mystery, when you do the Meddling Move in a place occupied by the rich and famous, you find an additional Clue, even on a miss.

Dale Cooper

Add 1 to your Sensitivity (max 3). At the beginning of each session, the Keeper will give you a Void Clue in the form of a strange, unsettling dream you experience. No two Mavens can have this move at the same time.

Sonny Crockett

You have a very stylish wardrobe—people say “Wow!” whenever they see you around town. Describe your Style in a little more detail and then add Stylish Wardrobe to your Cozy Little Place. When you use it to get an advantage on a die roll, leave it unmarked.

Frank Dowling

You have a strong religious background. Describe it. When you use this move, describe how your faith is helping you resist the Void. Then, unmark every box on The Crown of the Void. You are still Obsessed with the Void if you unmark the Pomegranate Kernel. You may only use this move once.

Tom Hanson

You can easily pass for someone much younger. If you're in a situation or environment where being younger is a benefit, your rolls are made with advantage.

Milton Hardcastle

You have an additional End of Session question that is always marked: “Did you inflict extrajudicial punishment on a wrongdoer?”

Jonathan Hart

You used to live a globetrotting, jet set life, and you still have a touch of glamor about you that will never fade. Add 1 to your Presence (max 3).

Angus MacGyver

When you improvise in a situation using whatever is at hand, ask the other players and Keeper to name three objects you find in the environment. So long as you can give a plausible explanation for how these three objects together are helpful in the current situation, you get an automatic 12+ on a single associated die roll. This move can be used once per mystery.

Thomas Magnum

You are a secret personal friend of Robin Masterson, the mysterious author of The Gold Crown Mysteries. You have access to Robin's resources whenever you are outside Brindlewood Bay: her homes, her vehicles, and even her checking account. Additionally, the Mavens always get both benefits of the Gold Crown Mysteries Move instead of having to choose.

Fox Mulder

Someone connected to the Dark Conspiracy is helping you behind the scenes. Tell the Keeper that the thresholds for each layer of the Dark Conspiracy are reduced by 1. Once per mystery, after at least one Void Clue has been encountered, you can have a secret meeting with this informant, who is always shrouded in darkness or otherwise disguised. You need only describe what the scene looks like—the location, the physical environment, how the mysterious person arrives on the scene, etc. The actual conversation happens off-screen. Then, you can declare that a Void Clue encountered during the mystery is now a regular Clue. The informant will only fully reveal themselves during the Void Mystery, at which point you can have normal scenes with them. No two Mavens can have this move at the same time.

Michael Knight

You have a trusty mode of transportation—an oversized sedan, a motorbike, or an old truck—that has gotten you out of more than one sticky situation. Give it a name and add it to your Cozy Little Place. When you use it to get an advantage on a die roll, leave it unmarked.

Rick & A.J.

You have a sibling who is your polar opposite in terms of fashion sense and personality. Describe them to the Keeper and name them. You can always request a scene with your sibling. You can also call on them for help, in which case you take advantage on any die rolls associated with actions they assist you with. However, that help always comes at a cost.

R. Quincy

You have a medical background; describe it. Then add a Medical Bag to your Cozy Little Place. When you use it to get an advantage on a die roll, leave it unmarked.

Jim Rockford

At the beginning of each session, the Keeper will narrate an answering machine message you received. The message is always from the same unknown person, and they will ask you to do some particular task, seemingly unrelated to the mystery. If you complete the task in the same session it was assigned, mark XP. The messages and tasks will get increasingly strange and disturbing the more marks you have on The Crown of the Void. No two Mavens can ever have this move at the same time.

Scarecrow

At the beginning of each session, a stranger presses something into your hand or leaves something in a place where you find it. The Keeper will tell you what it is. It functions as a Clue, but isn't attached to any particular mystery—you can use it in the present mystery or save it for the future.

Colt Seavers

Once per mystery, you can take a 12+ on a single roll related to a wild or daring physical feat.

Gordon Shumway

You have a feline friend with whom you share a strong bond. This extraordinary kitty can do tricks and follow simple commands. Name your precocious puss and add them to your Cozy Little Place. When you use the cat to get an advantage on a roll, leave it unmarked.

Remington Steele

You're very talented at passing yourself off as someone you are not. If there is a piece of identification or a disguise that would help you with your ruse, you have it. Say what it is and add it to your Cozy Little Place.

ALTERNATE MAVEN MOVES

*No two Mavens can have the same Maven move at the start. Additionally, a number of moves can only ever be taken by one Maven. Finally, **Robert Langdon** and **Clarice Starling** cannot be in the same game.*

Auguste Dupin

The first time you enter a Location, you can ask the Keeper, "What is about to happen?" They will answer truthfully, though not necessarily completely. If your Reason is 2 or higher, you can also ask, "Why is it about to happen?" The Keeper will answer truthfully, though not necessarily completely.

Father Brown

Once per mystery, you can narrate a flashback from the perspective of the unknown killer. Nothing in the flashback is necessarily true, but when you're done, ask the other Mavens to define a Clue based on what you narrated. The Clue cannot conclusively solve the mystery by itself.

Encyclopedia Brown

Once per mystery, you can introduce a piece of real-world trivia about something in a scene. That trivia is a Clue.

Nancy Drew

You know that Robin Masterson hasn't written an Amanda Delacourt book in years and that her name is used as a pseudonym by dozens of secret ghost writers because you are one of those secret ghost writers. So long as you keep the secret, the Mavens always get both benefits of the Gold Crown Mysteries Move instead of having to choose. If you ever reveal the secret to anyone, you get a second use of the Gold Crown Mysteries Move during the mystery in which you reveal it, but take the Condition: Marked by the Robin Masterson Network, and you no longer have access to this move. No two Mavens can have this move at the same time.

Tintin

You have a canine companion with whom you share a strong bond. This incredible pup can understand what you say with near-perfect comprehension. Name them and add them to your Cozy Little Place. They gain the power of speech once Layer 5 of the Dark Conspiracy is unlocked, but only you can understand them. No two Mavens can have this move at the same time.

Hercule Poirot

Increase your Reason by 1 (max 3).

Jane Marple

During the day, you can enter any place you wish, and move about freely once you're inside so long as you don't do anything actively hostile to any people who might be there.

Sherlock Holmes

The first time you encounter a Suspect, you can declare something about them based solely on their appearance. This information is absolutely true, but it is not a Clue, nor can it conclusively solve the mystery.

Robert Langdon

Once per mystery, you can change a physical object that is a Clue into a Void Clue by describing secret markings, unusual patterns, or otherwise strange, occult details that are on it. If you have unlocked Layer Three of the Dark Conspiracy, tell the Keeper that the thresholds for each remaining layer are reduced by one Void Clue. No two Mavens can have this move at the same time. This move and the Clarice Starling move cannot be in the same game.

Philip Marlowe

Once per mystery, so long as no other Maven is in the scene, you can do a first person narration of your arrival in a Location or your first encounter with a Suspect. Whatever you narrate is true, but it cannot conclusively solve the mystery. No two Mavens can have this move at the same time.

Mma Precious Ramotswe

You have two additional cozy activities; pick them from the list on your character sheet or write your own. Additionally, once per mystery, so long as you are engaged in one of your cozy activities, you can trigger the Cozy Move with a resident of Brindlewood Bay who is not a Maven. Finally, during the Cozy Move with another Maven, whichever Maven is doing their cozy activity can stumble on a Clue as normal OR clear another appropriate Condition.

Sam Spade

Something about you makes you seem like you have a bit of an edge. What is it? During the night, you can enter any place you wish, and move about freely once you're inside so long as you don't do anything actively hostile to any people who might be there.

Phoenix Wright

Whenever you find a Clue that is an object, you can physically manipulate the object to uncover a further secret about it—a hidden detail, a secret compartment, a scrawled message, etc. This extra detail is added to the Clue; it cannot cause the Clue to conclusively solve the mystery by itself.

Frank & Joe

Once per mystery, when you would suffer grave physical harm, describe how you are knocked unconscious instead. Take the Condition: A Little Rattled. You always wake up in the perfect place to continue the investigation.

Cadfael

You are a highly skilled herbalist and have an additional cozy activity: Herbalism. If there is an herbal tincture or decoction that would be helpful in a situation, you can take the time to make it. If you do, add it to your Cozy Little Place.

Clarice Starling

This move has no function until you solve a mystery and put a Suspect behind bars as a result. Thereafter, you can name an imprisoned Suspect your Consultant. Once per mystery, you can go to the prison the Consultant is being held in and ask them about that mystery. This triggers the Meddling Move as it would when questioning any other character, but the Consultant's answers and behavior are affected by your most recent mark on the Crown of the Void:

- No marks: The Consultant is mocking or insulting.
- A Shadow in the Garden: The Consultant claims to see malevolent spirits all around you.
- The Chariot: The Consultant reveals a Void Clue, even on a miss (but no extra effect on a 12+).
- The Pallid Mask: The Consultant also reveals the name of a character who will be killed if you don't do something to help them.
- The Pomegranate Kernel: The Consultant will also profess their love for you. If you reciprocate their love, clear Obsessed with the Void and lose access to this move. If you reject their love, take the Condition: Marked by (Name of Consultant) and lose access to this move. The Consultant will eventually escape and come after you.

No two Mavens can have this move at the same time. This move and the Robert Langdon move cannot be in the same game.

V.I. Warshawski

Increase your Vitality by 1 (max 3).

Nero Wolfe

Your Cozy Little Place is anything but. Add the following to it: Gourmet Pantry, Orchidarium, Full Bar, Private Elevator, House Boy (name him). No two Mavens can have this move at the same time.

Pick one or make up your own.

Style

- ☐ Alexis Carrington Colby
- ☐ All the Cardigans
- ☐ Blouse Barn
- ☐ Dorothy Zbornak
- ☐ Goin' Fishin'
- ☐ Hippy Dippy
- ☐ Jackie O
- ☐ Martha's Vineyard
- ☐ Office Hours
- ☐ Speed Walkin'
- ☐ Up in Pumps

Cozy Activity

☐ Antiques & Furniture	☐ Painting
☐ Baking	☐ Pottery
☐ Birding	☐ Quilting
☐ Charity Events	☐ Scrapbooking
☐ Cooking	☐ Collecting (Stamps, Buttons, Pressed Flowers,...)
☐ Gardening	
☐ Knitting	

Abilities

At the beginning of the game, add 1 to a single ability.

0	1	1	0	1
Vitality	Composure	Reason	Presence	Sensitivity

Conditions

BRINDLEWOOD —BAY—

End of Session

- ☒ Did the Murder Mavens solve a mystery?
- ☐ Did you secretly undermine the authority of a local official?
- ☐ Did you share your wisdom with a young person?
- ☐ Did you share a memory of a late family member?
- ☐ Did you behave like a woman half your age?
- ☐ Did you dote on someone?
- ☐ Did you show someone that you've "still got it?"

Advancements

XP □ □ □ □ □

- ☐ Increase an ability modifier by 1 (max 3).
- ☐ Increase an ability modifier by 1 (max 3).
- ☐ Choose an additional Maven move.
- ☐ Choose an additional Maven move.
- ☐ Unmark all the items in your Cozy Little Place.

Maven Moves

At the beginning of the game, select one move from the Maven moves sheet. No two Mavens can have the same Maven move at the beginning of the game.

The Crown of the Queen

When you put on this Crown, mark and narrate any you wish.

- ☐ A flashback of your fondest memory of your late partner.
- ☐ A flashback showing how you were an imperfect sister or daughter.
- ☐ A flashback showing how you were an imperfect mother.
- ☐ A flashback of your fondest memory with one of your children.
- ☐ A scene in the present day showing a private side of you very few get to see.
- ☐ A scene in the present day showing a burgeoning romance.
- ☐ A scene in the present day showing how you satisfy your physical desires.

The Crown of the Void

When you put on this Crown, mark the first empty box.

- ☐ **A Shadow in the Garden.** Hereafter, during cozy vignettes focused on you or Cozy Move scenes involving you, you must also narrate how dark entities subtly reveal themselves in the scene.
- ☐ **The Chariot.** Your Reason modifier is reduced by 1 and your Sensitivity modifier is increased by 1.
- ☐ **The Pallid Mask.** Hereafter, during any intimate conversation with another character, you must make a casual reference to death, dying, the afterlife, or the End of All Things—no matter the subject at-hand.
- ☐ **The Pomegranate Kernel.** You take the Condition: Obsessed with the Void. It can never be cleared.
- ☐ **The Void.** Retire your character in a way that shows how they are lost to the Void.

A Cozy Little Place

[illegible]

Pick one or make up your own.

Style

- ☐ Alexis Carrington Colby
- ☐ All the Cardigans
- ☐ Blouse Barn
- ☐ Dorothy Zbornak
- ☐ Goin' Fishin'
- ☐ Hippy Dippy
- ☐ Jackie O
- ☐ Martha's Vineyard
- ☐ Office Hours
- ☐ Speed Walkin'
- ☐ Up in Pumps

Cozy Activity

- ☐ Antiques & Furniture
- ☐ Baking
- ☐ Birding
- ☐ Charity Events
- ☐ Cooking
- ☐ Gardening
- ☐ Knitting
- ☐ Painting
- ☐ Pottery
- ☐ Quilting
- ☐ Scrapbooking
- ☐ Collecting (Stamps, Buttons, Pressed Flowers,...)

Abilities

0	1	1	0	1
Vitality	Composure	Reason	Presence	Sensitivity

Conditions

BRINDLEWOOD —BAY—

End of Session

- ☒ Did the Murder Mavens solve a mystery?
- ☐ Did you secretly undermine the authority of a local official?
- ☐ Did you share your wisdom with a young person?
- ☐ Did you share a memory of a late family member?
- ☐ Did you behave like a woman half your age?
- ☐ Did you dote on someone?
- ☐ Did you show someone that you've "still got it?"

Advancements

XP ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

- ☐ Increase an ability modifier by 1 (max 3).
- ☐ Increase an ability modifier by 1 (max 3).
- ☐ Choose an additional Maven move.
- ☐ Choose an additional Maven move.
- ☐ Unmark all the items in your Cozy Little Place.

Maven Moves

At the beginning of the game, select one move from the Maven moves sheet. No two Mavens can have the same Maven move at the beginning of the game.

The Crown of the Queen

When you put on this Crown, mark and narrate any you wish.

- ☐ A flashback of your fondest memory of your late partner.
- ☐ A flashback showing how you were an imperfect sister or daughter.
- ☐ A flashback showing how you were an imperfect mother.
- ☐ A flashback of your fondest memory with one of your children.
- ☐ A scene in the present day showing a private side of you very few get to see.
- ☐ A scene in the present day showing a burgeoning romance.
- ☐ A scene in the present day showing how you satisfy your physical desires.

The Crown of the Void

When you put on this Crown, mark the first empty box.

- ☐ **A Shadow in the Garden.** Hereafter, during cozy vignettes focused on you or Cozy Move scenes involving you, you must also narrate how dark entities subtly reveal themselves in the scene.
- ☐ **The Chariot.** Your Reason modifier is reduced by 1 and your Sensitivity modifier is increased by 1.
- ☐ **The Pallid Mask.** Hereafter, during any intimate conversation with another character, you must make a casual reference to death, dying, the afterlife, or the End of All Things—no matter the subject at-hand.
- ☐ **The Pomegranate Kernel.** You take the Condition: Obsessed with the Void. It can never be cleared.
- ☐ **The Void.** Retire your character in a way that shows how they are lost to the Void.

A Cozy Little Place

[illegible]

The Dark Conspiracy

Use this sheet to track the history, motivations, and actions of the Midwives of the Fragrant Void.

The First Void Clue...

...is always the Midwives' first appearance in the story.

It should be brief—perhaps the Mavens catch a glimpse of hooded, robed figures—and you should emphasize their masks, which are smooth and white, like the faces of marble statues in a Greek temple.

Layer One: The Midwives Scene

This layer is unlocked after the Mavens discover the FIRST Void Clue.

At the end of the session of play in which the first Void Clue is encountered, narrate a scene showing a group of hooded figures standing on a beach at night. The moon is high in the sky, causing their Greek statue masks to glow white as they reflect the moonlight. They begin chanting strange words, first under their breath, and then louder. The scene ends with a large, shadowy shape rising from the ocean, silhouetted by the moon.

Between sessions, write down some details about the Child of Persephone you think the Midwives are trying to summon. What will it do when summoned?

Note any characters who reveal themselves to be connected to the Dark Conspiracy.

Layer Two: The History of Brindlewood Bay

This layer is unlocked after the Mavens discover THREE Void Clues. You may reveal these details (in any order) as the result of a 12+ on the Meddling Move, or as a new Keeper reaction you now have access to: **Reveal the town history.**

- ☐ In the summer of 1877, the crew of the whaler *Deep Reaver* set out from Brindlewood Bay. They returned with the strangest whale anyone had ever seen. It had tentacle-like legs and rows of oily, black eyes. They sold its parts all over the world, and the proceeds were used to turn Brindlewood Bay into what it is today.
- ☐ In the spring of 1942, wreckage from a Nazi U-boat washed ashore at Brindlewood Bay. The U-boat appeared to have been torn to pieces—literally ripped apart—and some of the interior bulkheads had strange, occult symbols scrawled all over them. No bodies ever turned up, but there was one reported survivor: a Nazi submariner whose mind was shattered and who committed suicide by repeatedly slamming his head into a wall shortly after being detained. The U.S. government gathered the pieces of the wreckage before it could become a major story in the papers.
- ☐ In 1967, during the Summer of Love, a hippie commune sprung up just outside Brindlewood Bay. The members of the commune largely kept to themselves, only occasionally coming into town for supplies. The people of Brindlewood Bay began to hear rumors that the commune was engaging in Satanic rituals and other dark, orgiastic magic. When a young boy, George Maplethorpe, went missing, the commune was blamed. A young Wyman Dalrymple, future sheriff of Brindlewood County, lead a citizens' march to the commune in response. Once there, violence broke out. No one can say for certain what happened to the hippies, but none have been heard from since, and their facilities were burned to the ground. Little George Maplethorpe was never found.
- ☐ In the fall of 1992, a group of anti-government separatists called the Sons of Freedom had a standoff against federal agents at the Sons' compound deep in the woods outside Brindlewood Bay. The standoff lasted for six days, during which time federal agents claimed to witness all manner of strange things coming from the compound: bizarre lights, chanting, barnyard animal noises, and more.

Some agents report having hallucinations during the standoff, and even glimpsing monstrous forms in the surrounding woods. On the sixth night, a wild chanting followed by terrible screams went up from the compound, and then silence. When agents entered the compound, they found an abattoir—the floors, walls, and ceilings soaked in blood, and pieces of the Sons strewn all over.

- ☐ New Year's Eve, 2011: Brindlewood Bay was the convergence point for numerous doomsday prophets who believed the world would end in 2012. A massive "End of All Things" party was held in and around town, and the next day, most of the revelers went back to wherever they came from. A few, however, remained...

Between sessions, write down the name of a character you'd like to see return during the Void Mystery.

Take some time to revise your idea about the Child of Persephone and why the Midwives are trying to summon it.

Note any new characters who reveal themselves to be connected to the Dark Conspiracy.

The Dark Conspiracy

Layer Three: The Existence of the Midwives of the Fragrant Void

This layer is unlocked after the Mavens discover FIVE Void Clues. You may reveal these details, in order, as the result of a 12+ on *The Meddling Move*, or as a new Keeper reaction you now have access to: **Reveal the Midwives**.

- ☐ The Mavens hear the words "The Midwives of the Fragrant Void" for the first time.
- ☐ The leader of the Midwives makes themselves known to the Murder Mavens, though they may not necessarily reveal their position in or affiliation with the cult. Write the name of this character on the line below.

Leader of the Midwives:

- ☐ The Murder Mavens stumble onto direct, physical evidence of the existence of the cult, perhaps the remnants of a recently-performed ritual.
- ☐ A character the Mavens believed was an ally or friend is revealed to be a member of the Midwives.

Between sessions, revise your idea about what the Midwives are trying to accomplish.

Note any new characters who reveal themselves to be connected to the Dark Conspiracy.

Layer Four: Direct Action Against the Murder Mavens

This layer is unlocked after the Mavens discover TEN Void Clues. The Midwives can now take direct action against the Murder Mavens. You have a new Keeper reaction available to you: **Magic of the Midwives**.

Sendings

The Midwives can perform rituals that allow them to magically assault their enemies. Whenever they do so, cut away from the current scene and narrate a scene in which we see the Midwives performing their ritual, and then cut to a scene showing the calamitous effects of their sorcery.

Servitors

The Midwives can summon low-level supernatural entities to do their bidding. What do these creatures look like? What kinds of powers do they have? How can they be stopped?

Between sessions, make one final revision about the Child of Persephone and the Midwives' plan.

Layer Five: The Void Mystery

This layer is unlocked after the Mavens discover FIFTEEN Void Clues.

You may now create the Void Mystery following the guidelines in the rules. You may present the Void Mystery once the current mystery is resolved. After the conclusion of the Void Mystery, give each player a chance to narrate an epilogue for their Maven. This game of **BRINDLEWOOD DAY** is now complete. We hope you enjoyed your stay in this picturesque, coastal town.

Mystery Tracker

Mystery Name: _____

Resolution: _____

Mystery Name: _____

Resolution: _____

Mystery Name: _____

Resolution: _____

Mystery Name: _____

Resolution: _____

Mystery Name: _____

Resolution: _____

Mystery Name: _____

Resolution: _____

Dad Overboard

Presenting the Mystery

Complexity: 6

Present this mystery at the top floor of The Candlelight Booksellers, during the weekly meeting of the Murder Mavens mystery book club.

Paint the Scene: *As the camera pans around the loft where you hold your Murder Mavens meetings, what do we see that shows how you have personalized the space?*

Just as their meeting is ending, the Mavens are approached by Brindlewood County's chief law enforcement officer, Sheriff Wyman Dalrymple. He tells them that, earlier today, a wealthy financier, Albert Krause, was dragged out of the bay, dead. Mr. Krause and his family were on a yachting vacation and their boat is presently anchored a quarter mile from shore. The surviving Krauses—wife Allison, eldest daughter Sara, son David, and youngest daughter Emily—assert Mr. Krause was drunk and simply fell overboard. Sheriff Dalrymple suspects foul play but if he can't produce evidence to that effect soon, he'll be forced to let the family take Albert back to Boston. The body is currently being held in a cold storage at the fish market until the matter can be sorted out.

Establishing Question: *You met one of the Krause children several years ago. What were the circumstances around that meeting?*

Sheriff Dalrymple needs the Mavens' help in proving foul play. He emphasizes to them that he does not need them to solve the whole mystery—that's what the sheriff's department is for. Of course, Murder Mavens are going to do what Murder Mavens are going to do...

Moments

- A young woman in a black hoodie peeks over the top of a copy of *The Murders in the Rue Morgue and Other Chilling Tales* as the Mavens come down from their meeting.
- A young family on vacation: the mother is doing her best to keep her tired, unruly children calm.
- A pair of grizzled, salt-encrusted locals sneer at a dewy social media influencer making a video. "Hi, guys!"

- A fishmonger rolls an ice-packed cart past you; it's a cornucopia of the sea: black sea bass, bluefish, mussels, crabs, and more.
- A small child wails in anguish—pure, heartrending sorrow—as they watch their ice cream cone melt on the boardwalk.
- An evening meal in Brindlewood Bay: "Casual" string lights, pristine table linens, white plates with anchor and whale motifs.

Suspects

Sheriff Wyman Dalrymple, an official

Jowly, paunchy, speaks with a permanently exasperated tone. Without anything to go on, he'll have to let the Krauses raise anchor and leave. He's reluctant to ask the Murder Mavens for their help, but he knows they have had some success solving cases in the past.

Quote: *"Believe you me, no one is more frustrated about having to ask for help from a bunch of old biddies than I am!"*

Allison Krause, the wife

Thin. Graceful. Well-dressed. Naturally, she's upset about the death of her husband, but she seems equally distraught about how all of this might affect the 4th Annual Warrior's Ball, an upcoming charity event for veterans suffering from testicular cancer that she's hosting a week from now.

Quote: *"It's just like Albert to go and get himself killed when I'm on the precipice of charity fundraiser greatness! The man could be so self-involved!"*

Sara Krause, a daughter

Frumpy. Easily cowed. Hand-wringy. She's a homemaker with three little ones back in Boston (Portia, Mercedes, and Lambo). She seems to be the only person who is genuinely upset about Mr. Krause's death.

Quote: *"Do you really think someone could have murdered my father? It's—it's too horrible to even contemplate!"*

David Krause, the son

Snippy. Avant-garde fashion sense. Can't be bothered. David is eager to return to running his art gallery back in Boston. He has nothing good to say about his father.

Quote: *"I'm reminded, of course, of the great performance artist Gao Bai, who was so committed to his work, he threw himself from the top of a five-story building—the ultimate artistic expression, if you ask me. If only my father's death could have been so significant. He lacked vision."*

Emily Krause, a daughter

Withdrawn. Computer nerd. Somewhat awkward. Seems indifferent to her father's death. Very preoccupied with an ongoing conversation she's having online.

Quote: *"Umm... can we put a pin in this for a sec? I just have to reply to this DM real quick."*

Andrew, the butler

Gray hair. Fastidious. Eloquent. Andrew is doing his best to look after the Krauses during this tumultuous time. He seems to dote on Allison the most.

Quote: *"Madam, the dinner table for this evening is set-up on the forecastle and awaiting your inspection."*

Captain Curly, the yacht captain

Dazzling officer's whites. Megawatt smile. Gray at the temples. Captain Carl "Curly" Willoughby has worked for the Krause family for years. He's a Brindlewood Bay native, and the reason the family vacations here.

Quote: *"I convinced Mr. and Mrs. Krause to start coming out this way about ten years ago. Brindlewood Bay was a backwater as far as they were concerned, but I've been slowly teaching them about the local history and culture. Are you a native of Brindlewood Bay?"*

Etienne Beauregard, a fishmonger

Silver beard. Hale. Does a "romantic Frenchman of the sea" performance for tourists, but is actually from Scranton. Etienne is an old friend of the Krauses, and has agreed to store Albert's body as a kindness to the family.

Quote: *"I'd do anything for the Krauses. Everything I have in this world is because of them. When they told me they needed somewhere cold to store Albert's body, I was more than happy to make room between the cod and the pollock."*

Dad Overboard

Locations

The marina

The smell of saltspray in the air. Gulls declaiming overhead. A mix of locals and tourists.

Paint the Scene: *It's a busy time of year at the marina. In what ways are the tourists making it difficult for you to conduct your investigation?*

The fish market

Fishmongers tossing bass back and forth, a performance for the crowd. Wet grit beneath your shoes. Edison lights strung overhead.

Paint the Scene: *What do you see that reminds you why you love the fish market? Or, what about this place makes you hate coming down here?*

Back of the fish market

The chill of the cold storage. Surly sorts having a cigarette. A strong, fishy smell.

Paint the Scene: *You have the feeling you're being watched. What makes you think this?*

The Regal Lady, the Krause family yacht

Blindingly white. Everything polished to a shine. "Tu Vuò Fa' L'Americano" playing on the speaker system.

Paint the Scene: *As you step aboard the yacht, what do you see that shows these people have more money than they know what to do with?*

Clues

- ☐ A blood-soaked rug.
- ☐ Family pictures, discarded.
- ☐ A mis-reported detail about the time of Albert's death.
- ☐ A wristwatch set to the wrong time.
- ☐ A diary entry: "I just can't take it anymore."
- ☐ A small handgun, like you might keep in a purse.
- ☐ Stock certificates in a strange hiding place.
- ☐ Piles of receipts for extravagant purchases.
- ☐ A guest list for an upcoming Krause family party, with one name conspicuously crossed out.
- ☐ An attempt to collect a debt.
- ☐ An argument between two Suspects on the deck of The Regal Lady; the words they're saying are unclear.
- ☐ An antique vase—a family heirloom—shattered.
- ☐ A love letter from a young military vet.
- ☐ An expensive diamond earring, its mate missing.
- ☐ A cod with a rat stuffed in its mouth.
- ☐ A sequence of numbers written on a slip of paper.
- ☐ Documents that call into question the paternity of a child.
- ☐ Instructions to cut someone out of a will.
- ☐ A taboo love affair.
- ☐ An expensive samoyed, missing.

Void Clues

- ☐ A fish, dying, strange purple ooze seeping from its beady, black eyes.
- ☐ At first, the growling, repetitive noise of some machine, but upon further inspection, the sound of chanting coming from somewhere dark and down below.
- ☐ Tattoos that seem to have shifted position when you look at them again.
- ☐ A group of people praying near the spot where Mr. Krause's body was found. They will not interact with anyone, and disperse if someone gets too pushy.
- ☐ A fish, seemingly dead, speaks a single word: "Void."
- ☐ Nighttime shadows appear to plume and swirl, like ink dripped into a glass of water.

Notes

All Hallow's Scream

Presenting the Mystery

Complexity: 6

The Mavens are guests at a Halloween party being thrown at the fabulous Brindlewood Bay home of Abner and Coco Vidal. Abner, a retired filmmaker famous for gonzo, B-grade pictures greets the Mavens at the front door; he is wearing a King Tut costume.

Paint the Scene: *As you approach the Vidals' home, what ostentatious thing do you see outside that reminds you the Vidals don't fit in with Brindlewood Bay's stuffy upper crust? Also: tell me about your costume.*

After a short scene with Abner, have a few more scenes where we see the Mavens enjoying themselves at the party, which principally takes place at or near the bar. Be sure to introduce all the Suspects in these scenes.

After a few scenes, and after the Suspects have been introduced, the party is interrupted by a shrill scream. Mrs. White has found Abner dead on the covered back porch, his head submerged in a large metal basin being used to bob for apples.

The Mavens can begin investigating right away or they can wait for someone from the sheriff's department to be called to the scene. No matter what, it's important that no one be allowed to leave the Vidals' home until everyone can be questioned. Make it clear to the players that the sheriff's department is entirely incompetent and will not be able to crack the case without the Mavens' help. If you need a character from law enforcement, use Sheriff Dalrymple from Dad Overboard, or Deputy Brett Anderson, a himbo beach cop, in the event Sheriff Dalrymple was implicated in the Dad Overboard murder.

Establishing Question: *You're having a secret affair with one of the people you've talked to at the party tonight. Who is it?*

Moments

- Partygoers dancing to the "Monster Mash."
- An animatronic werewolf from *Werewolf Sings the Blues* welcomes partygoers with a song.

- Lobby posters of some of Abner's greatest hits: *Return of the Devil Women from Planet X*, *Zombie High School*, *Barracuda II: The 'Cuda Sleeps at Night*, and *Barracuda VIII: 'Cuda in Space*.
- A movie theater concession stand is not in operation, but smells of hot buttered popcorn.
- TV monitors throughout the house play scenes from *March of the Devil Women from Planet X* on a silent loop.
- A group of trick-or-treaters at the front door: Spider-Man, Pink Power Ranger, Happy Jack the Lumberjack.

Suspects

Coco Vidal, the wife

Air-headed. Sweet. Cleopatra costume. Coco has known Abner since they were teenagers and was frequently an extra in his early films. They've been married for nearly forty years.

Quote: *"Why would anyone want to kill Abner? He's so harmless. It's true he snores quite a lot, and he's sometimes a bit of a cheapskate when it comes to dining out, but why would anyone want to kill him over stuff like that?"*

Mrs. White, maid

Curmudgeonly. Snoops about. Maid uniform with cat ears. Mrs. White is quiet and always... there. She knows a lot about what happens in the Vidal home. Secretly in love with Coco.

Quote: *"Mr. Vidal was bound to go and get himself killed at some point. You can't make that many pictures about madness and murder and not have the real thing come knocking on your door at some point. I'm surprised it took this long! The person I'm most worried about is poor Mrs. Vidal. Someone needs to make sure she's looked after."*

Elena Visage, an actress

Seductive. Boozy. Vampiress costume. Elena is a former Hollywood actress and frequent star of Abner's films. She seems to like Abner, though she will drop hints that he eventually resigned her to "matronly" roles in favor of giving the leads to younger talent.

Quote: *"I mean, surely you've seen my work? Variety once said my performance in Devil Women from Planet X was the most acting they'd ever seen."*

Gordon Thune, a banker

Stuffy. Put-upon. Frankenstein's monster costume. Gordon is a local banker and a pillar of the community. He finds Abner personally distasteful, and if not for the filmmaker's importance as a bank customer, wouldn't be caught dead at this party.

Quote: *"Who knows what kind of depraved nonsense Abner has planned for us at this party. These Hollywood types... they're just different from you and me, you know?"*

Sam Turlington, a business partner

Friendly. Boisterous. Phantom of the Opera costume. Sam is a new business partner of Abner's—they're investing in some prime retail property near the bay. He likes Abner and is having a swell time at the party.

Quote: *"I'll tell you this: Abner Vidal isn't just a film visionary. No, no—he's also got a great mind for business. The plans we're hatching for the seaside properties are going to make Brindlewood Bay an internationally-renowned vacation spot."*

Marcus Greaves, the manager

Handsome. Piercing eyes. No costume. Marcus is Abner's business manager. He's been with Abner for over twenty years, looking after his affairs, arranging opportunities, negotiating contracts... and always getting his ten percent.

Quote: *"These parties are such a waste of time. The people in this backwater—no offense—are never going to accept Abner as one of their own, so I'm not sure why he even tries. I need to get him back to Hollywood—Los Angeles misses Abner Vidal. I know he's upset about how poorly 'Cuda Girl? Barracuda in Love was received, but anyone could have told you that long-time fans of the Barracuda franchise were never going to accept a rom-com twist!"*

June Willoughby, a local socialite

Pretty. Artificially genteel. Sock-hop costume. A local and friend of the Vidals. Secretly having an affair with Abner. Very judgmental towards Coco.

Quote: *"Just look at this place. Everything is so ostentatious. And it's just like Coco to buy this cheap swill. Zhampagne! Whoever heard of Zhampagne?"*

All Hallow's Scream

Locations

The bar

This is where the mystery starts—a bar and lounge area just off the foyer.

Paint the Scene: *The room has been decorated for Halloween using props from Abner's horror movies. Come up with a name for one of Abner's schlock masterpieces and then describe the prop from that movie.*

The Tinseltown room

Dramatic art deco lines. Lots of black lacquer and gold trim. Thick carpets.

Paint the Scene: *As you step inside this sitting room, what do you see that shows it's a temple to Old Hollywood.*

The master bedroom

Blood red wallpaper and curtains. Enormous canopy bed. Mirrors overhead.

Paint the Scene: *Abner and Coco had a pretty interesting sex life. What evidence of this do you see casually strewn about the room?*

Abner's office

A framed dollar bill with no particular significance. A top-of-the line computer, still boxed. A talking 'Cuda the Barracuda mounted to the wall sings "Bad to the Bone" if you press a button.

Paint the Scene: *Abner is very bad at business. Looking around his office, how do you know this?*

The screening room

Red velvet movie theater seats. Sconces glowing warmly. The click click click of a film reel.

Paint the Scene (*only if at least one Maven has marked A Shadow in the Garden*): *The film being played, about a hippie commune, is one you don't recognize. The film is in black and white, and there is no audio. It captures the last, violent moments of the commune, with buildings burning and people bloodied and running in terror. What do you see that makes you think the events being depicted are real? The film is a Void Clue.*

Clues

- ☐ A shattered Britty Award.
- ☐ An argument between two Suspects on a seemingly private balcony; the words they're saying are unclear.
- ☐ A plastic pumpkin filled with half-empty pill bottles; painkillers, mostly.
- ☐ Decorative spider webs with a real human finger tangled in them.
- ☐ A stack of rejected movie scripts: Devil Women from Planet X vs. Zombie High School, Barracuda XII: 'Cudaz n the Hood, and Vampire Toga Party III: Magnus Cums Loudly.
- ☐ A pair of muddy boots in an unusual place.
- ☐ An old reel of film showing a debauched Hollywood party.
- ☐ Women's lingerie, perfumed.
- ☐ A secret passage connects two Locations.
- ☐ A sack of rubber Halloween masks in an unusual place.
- ☐ A steamy love letter, unsigned.
- ☐ A fancy car, the brake lines cut.
- ☐ Pictures of the past, discarded.
- ☐ An adult trick-or-treater provokes a glint of recognition from a Suspect.
- ☐ A phone message delivered to the wrong number.
- ☐ A lifetime achievement award with the words "Enjoy it, you worthless bastard" carved on the back of the frame.
- ☐ A tape of spooky Halloween sounds has a message from someone when played in reverse: "I know I'm going to die tonight."
- ☐ Candy that has been tampered with.
- ☐ A duplicate costume, hastily discarded.
- ☐ A rejected building permit application.

Void Clues

- ☐ The sound of a record being played backwards, but upon closer inspection, the sound of ritual chanting.
- ☐ A rising mist, strange shapes moving within.
- ☐ Insects pouring out of a jack-o'-lantern.
- ☐ A tree oozing blood-red sap.
- ☐ The electricity goes out, causing the music to come to a groaning stop. You can hear feverish sounds in the darkness: lovemaking, death throes, barnyard animal noises. When the lights come on again, everything is normal.
- ☐ A character depicted on a lobby poster for The Twelve Sexy Labors of Hercules beckons to you.

Notes

The GBBBO (The Great Brindlewood Bay Bake-Off)

Presenting the Mystery

Complexity: 7

The most popular television program in the world, *The Jolly Good Baking Show*, has come to Brindlewood Bay to find the town's very best baker. A number of qualifying rounds have been held, and our Murder Mavens are among the bakers to make it through to the final, televised portion of the show, where they will meet the charming presenters and have their confections judged by the notoriously strict Paul and Jane.

The first scene depicts the opening round of the competition: pies. Go around the table and ask each player to describe what sort of pie their Maven is making. Then, ask the player to their left whether the pie is a triumph or rather disappointing. If a Maven's cozy activity is baking, their pie is automatically a triumph. Then, the other players and the Keeper should each offer a detail about how the pie was beautifully executed if it was a triumph, or a detail about how it was a disaster if it was rather disappointing. During this process, the entire cast of Suspects should be introduced, as well as the steely-eyed, silver-haired judge, Paul Riviera. You can do this by having the Suspects interject with commentary or words of support, or have them do something technical related to the television production. Lots of hugs are in order.

There is a short break in filming after the pie round, during which a Suspect (your choice) will find Paul Riviera dead in his trailer, his face covered with flour and his hands tied behind his back with beautifully-plaited nylon cords. Security around the show is tight, and most of the production team was away from the set during the break. The only people who were still on set, and therefore had the means to kill Paul, are the Suspects.

Members of the production team will naturally be quite shocked by Paul's death, but they insist that everyone keep calm and carry on with the show. A responding authority, perhaps Sheriff Wyman Dalrymple, will ask the Murder Mavens to help figure out who did it, since they're in the mix and therefore in a position to question people during the filming of the remainder of the competition. If they can solve the crime without causing a stir, all the better.

During the investigation, one more round of baking competition should take place: cakes. For this round, have each player find a picture of a fabulous cake on the internet, using their smartphone or whatever technology is at-hand. That's the cake their Maven baked. The winner of the competition is determined by the Keeper.

If the mystery isn't solved by the end of the competition, the investigation can extend over as many hours or days as are needed. The Suspects won't be allowed to leave Brindlewood Bay until the culprit is brought to justice.

Establishing Question: *The Jolly Good Baking Show is connected to one of your favorite memories. What is that memory?*

Moments

- Melanie begins having a breakdown; Sue and Timothy rush over to comfort her. Scott quips: "That's a lot of emotion for pie."
- Someone forgot to turn their oven on, leading to no end of sturm and drang. Heath looks delighted and orders Buck to capture every agonizing moment on camera.
- Someone's bake looks like a cock. Everyone laughs except Jane, who doesn't understand what's so funny and will you please stop it, you lot, we have a show to make.
- Someone's bake is a triumph and they are rewarded with a coveted Paul Riviera shoulder rub.
- Timothy and/or Sue reveals, for the one hundredth time, they don't know anything about baking.
- A producer asks you to answer a question for the camera: Can you tell us what's going into your bake? Who's your biggest competition here? Which judge intimates you more? Why is it important for you to win this competition?

Suspects

Jane Leaf, a judge

Sweetly judgmental. Elderly. Posh. Jane is a beloved celebrity in the U.K., having published dozens of cookery books and made hundreds of television appearances over a career spanning nearly sixty years. Like all the other stars of *The Jolly Good Baking Show*, her contract is up for renewal, and she has lately grown frustrated with Paul's hardball negotiation tactics, which threaten to shut down the show entirely.

Quote: "Don't fret, dear—your pie has a perfectly adequate taste. It just looks a bit... informal."

Sue Mellon, a presenter

Boisterous. Punny. A hugger. Sue had been a very successful comedian in the U.K. She took this presenter job when her comedy career started to flatline. She is secretly jealous of Paul, who is the breakout star of *The Jolly Good Baking Show*.

Quote: "Bakers! Lattice be a warning to you: only five minutes remaining in the pie round!"

Timothy Boosh, a presenter

Weirdly large. Broad humor. Goth. Timothy is mostly along for the ride. He doesn't know the first thing about baking and feels very lucky to have stumbled into this gig.

Quote: "Bakers! You have thirty minutes remaining in this round!" (Pours a glass of water over his head and then does an awkward cartwheel for some reason.)

Scott Lamb, a contestant

Organized. Fond of bow ties. Twink. Scott was a contestant on *The Jolly Good Baking Show* three years ago. He famously went home after an explosive, on-camera argument with Paul about a pan of over-baked muffins. Many viewers, however, believe there's more to that story, with some suggesting the two were secretly lovers. In a bit of stunt casting, the show's producers have invited Scott to participate in this special episode, going so far as to rent him an apartment in town so he can technically be said to live in Brindlewood Bay.

Quote: "It's very important to blind bake the pie crust so you don't have a soggy bottom, because believe you me: Paul likes a neat, firm, uncomplicated bottom."

The GBBBO (The Great Brindlewood Bay Bake-Off)

Melanie Blair, a contestant

Seemingly frazzled. Actually intense. Sensibly-dressed. Melanie has lived in Brindlewood Bay all her life, and learned to bake from her parents, who used to own The Sweet Sensations Bakery before it went out of business.

Quote: *"Yes, it's true my parents' bakery went out of business when Paul's bakery chain opened a location in Brindlewood Bay, but I won't hold that against him. I love The Jolly Good Baking Show, and I'm just so honored to be here."*

Heath Hendricks, a producer

Stern. Balding. Excessive use of "3... 2... 1" fingers. Heath is overworked and irritable. He is furious that Paul Riviera has been threatening to leave the show if his (ridiculous) contractual demands are not met.

Quote: *"Do I sometimes daydream about him being dead? Absolutely. But did I kill him? No way. Paul Riviera may be a pompous, arrogant ass, but he's our pompous, arrogant ass."*

Buck, a cameraman

Good-humored. Handsome. Poetic. Buck, an American, has only been with *The Jolly Good Baking Show* for a few months, after his secret lover, Donna Riviera, got him the job.

Quote: *"This whole situation is just so unbearably tragic. The Jolly Good Baking Show is one of the few lights we have in this dark, dismal world. Tell me another show that can bring people together like this one can—young and old, rich and poor, black and white. It's something we can all agree on, you know? And now that Paul is gone, it will never be the same. That light is just a little bit dimmer now."*

Donna Riviera, the wife

Bottle blonde. Leopard print. Piles of make-up. Like her husband, Donna Riviera is a celebrity, having starred in the short-lived reality television program, *The Real Scouswives of Liverpool*. She has been having an affair with Buck for the last few months.

Quote: *"I can't believe someone would kill him, like. Mind you, he was always doing my head in—if anyone had a reason to sack him off, it's me. But I didn't do it. And now if you'll excuse me, I need a bifter and a bevvie to take the edge off, like."*

Locations

Jane's trailer

Enormous arrangements of English roses flanking everything. The Union Jack in a prominent place. The space is somehow in soft focus.

Paint the Scene: *As you step into the trailer, what do you see that reflects Jane's very posh femininity?*

Sue's trailer

Shelves full of British snacks and sweets: Tiddlynips, Bumblecracks, Wobbly Wums, and Nob Noms. Sapphic art all over. The smell of patchouli.

Paint the Scene: *Sue has a reverence for the great comedians that came before her. What do you see in her trailer that reinforces this idea?*

Timothy's trailer

The Cure playing on the stereo, of course. Blacklight posters. An obelisk in one corner.

Paint the Scene: *What do you see in Timothy's trailer that suggests he is a deeply lonely person?*

The judges' tent

Production folk just out of frame. A backdrop meant to depict Brindlewood Bay is actually Martha's Vineyard. Red, white, and blue bunting.

Paint the Scene: *The judges' tent is normally decorated to look like a quaint cottage somewhere in the English countryside, but has been given an "American" flair for this special episode. What sort of "American" gewgaws do you see?*

Notes

Clues

- ☐ A baking sheet sprinkled with rat poison.
- ☐ A text message of someone professing their love.
- ☐ A cookbook authored by Jane Leaf and Paul Riviera, but with one of Paul's recipes torn out.
- ☐ An unreasonable contractual demand.
- ☐ A missing chef's knife.
- ☐ A pile of receipts suggesting extravagant expenditures.
- ☐ A shattered Britty award.
- ☐ A dangerously-frayed electrical cord.
- ☐ A heated argument about British politics.
- ☐ A Buckingham Palace invite to the cast and crew of *The Jolly Good Baking Show*, with one name conspicuously missing.
- ☐ Stacks of love letters from the British Prime Minister.
- ☐ A dressing-down from the head of the BBC.
- ☐ Extremely valuable diamond earrings shaped like tiny loaves of bread.
- ☐ A plea for financial help.
- ☐ A sheet cake with a very hateful message written in blood-red icing on it.
- ☐ A pair of plane tickets to somewhere far, far away.
- ☐ Ball gag, handcuffs, and a riding crop.
- ☐ Outtakes suggesting a very tense, off-camera relationship.
- ☐ A rolling pin spattered with blood.
- ☐ Paul's body has signs of him being poisoned.

Void Clues

- ☐ A swarm of insects where food should be.
- ☐ The shadow of something unnatural crawling atop the baking tent.
- ☐ A tray of gingerbread men engaged in lurid acts, like on a Greek vase.
- ☐ A food canister that smells of urine, semen, and sweat.
- ☐ Brindlewood Bay locals watching the filming are suddenly seen wearing smooth, stone masks.
- ☐ For a moment, an oven seems impossibly vast and dark on the inside.

Jingle Bell Shock

Presenting the Mystery

Complexity: 7

It's the holiday season, and the Murder Mavens are out caroling as part of the Brindlewood Bay Lunch Club's annual Ugly Christmas Sweater Carol-a-thon fundraiser. Go around the table and ask each player to describe their Maven's ugly Christmas sweater.

The carolers arrive at the grand home of Amelia Hawthorne, and are a few bars into a rousing rendition of "We Three Kings" when a tall, middle-aged woman in a red suit steps out onto the porch and asks the group if they'd be willing to sing a funeral dirge instead. The woman will introduce herself to the group as Caroline Hawthorne, Amelia's niece. It seems Amelia was just found dead in her bedroom, strangled with a strand of pearls.

If the Mavens go inside the house, they'll find all the Suspects gathered in the foyer. Amelia was in her late sixties, and very wealthy after shrewdly investing her inheritance decades ago. She never married and, apart from her beloved Pekingese, Chestnut IV, lived alone. The Suspects are all family members from out of town.

The rest of the carolers will leave to get help from the police, but the Mavens should stay and conduct an investigation. Caroline will introduce herself and the other Suspects by name and relation to Amelia.

Establishing Question: *Amelia Hawthorne is a pariah in Brindlewood Bay. She's known to be miserly and cruel, and more than happy to throw her weight around with the town council in order to get her way. Very few people will be sad to hear she's dead, but you once saw a different side of her, a moment that humanized her. What happened?*

Moments

- The crunch of boots on snow, the smell of oranges in the air, and the tinkling of silver bells in the distance.
- The sweet and subtle smell of birch as it burns in a grand fireplace.
- An enormous charcuterie board filled with treats: cured meats, olives, crackers, several cheeses, fruits and veg, dipping sauces, crusty bread slices, and more.
- *It's a Wonderful Life* playing on an old console television set.

- A tapestry depicts a Currier & Ives scene: straw-haired boys playing in the snow; their dog yaps silently from the porch of their quaint home.
- A corkboard with Christmas cards from the gas company, the power company, and Amelia's life insurance provider—dozens collected over the years.

Suspects

Caroline Hawthorne, the niece

Assertive. Wry. Well-tailored women's suit. Caroline is, practically-speaking, the head of the Hawthorne family. While the family's money can be traced back to Aunt Amelia, it's Caroline who organizes everything, gives it form. She makes sure everyone is taken care of, financially-speaking, and that this annual pilgrimage to kiss Amelia's ring takes place. Caroline is Thomas's daughter, Avery's wife, and Everett and Skyler's mother.

Quote: *"We certainly have our differences, but the thing you need to understand about this family is that we are, first and foremost, Hawthornes. That comes before everything and everyone."*

Thomas Hawthorne, a brother

Cautious. Soft-spoken. Plum-colored smoking jacket. Thomas was Amelia's brother and financial adviser. He quietly resents Amelia since he's the one who helped her with the investments that made her rich, and if not for the fact that he was cut out of their parents' will, would have been able to make those investments for himself. Thomas is Caroline's father, and Everett and Skyler's grandfather.

Quote: *"My sister was a very complicated woman. She had a depth to her—a secret way of being that very few people understood. As much as I'm loath to admit it, I will miss her."*

Jimmy Hawthorne, a brother

Red-faced. Drunken. New England Patriots sweater. Uncle Jimmy was Amelia's brother, a thrice-divorced black sheep of the Hawthorne family. He can't hold down a job, and is always begging the other family members for money. He and Amelia hated each other with a white-hot passion, though the exact reason why has always been unclear.

Quote: *"Ding-dong, the witch is dead!" (Takes another drink and passes out.)*

Magdalena Hawthorne, the sister-in-law

Knowing smile. Constantly shuffling a deck of tarot cards. Ridiculously large silver cross around her neck. Magdalena is one of Jimmy's ex-wives. She is a deeply spiritual woman who blends her Catholic faith with more esoteric beliefs. Amelia gave her the money to open her Los Angeles New Age shop back in the late '80s. Magdalena is generally considered to be the only friend Amelia had.

Quote: *"I arrived earlier today. I drew a card from my deck as soon as I crossed the threshold of the front door: the Nine of Swords. That's a very bad sign—a sign of conflict—and I knew right away something terrible was going to happen. The cards never lie..."*

Everett Hawthorne, the great-nephew

Ridiculously handsome. Excessive use of "finger guns." Oversized cable knit sweater. Everett is a movie star, and likely the only Suspect the Mavens immediately recognize. He's most famous for the Turk Huntington series of spy films, each of which has been a global blockbuster. Everett is Caroline and Avery's son, and Skyler's brother.

Quote: *"Trust me: everyone in this room—except me, because I'm already rich as fuck—wants to know how much Aunt Amelia left them in her will. But knowing her, she left every red penny to Chestnut IV and all the other Chestnuts to come."*

Skyler Hawthorne, the great-niece

Tall. Beautiful. Bohemian chic. Skyler is a runway model who has worked for some of the biggest fashion houses in the world. She dislikes the other Hawthornes, but especially her brother, whom she believes received preferential treatment from the family elders. Skyler is Caroline and Avery's daughter, and Everett's sister.

Quote: *"My brother wasn't always a leading man in life. Growing up, he was chubby, he had a huge nose, and he stuttered really badly. But Aunt Amelia loved him—almost as much as she loved those damn dogs—and she helped him. It turns out you can turn a frog into a prince with enough money."*

Jingle Bell Shock

Avery Partridge, the nephew by marriage

Bitter. Sneering. Golf shirt and khakis. Avery runs a successful real estate business with his wife, Caroline. He doesn't have much love for any of the Hawthornes, but he absolutely despises Amelia, who made giving his children the Hawthorne name a condition of getting seed money for the business. Avery is Caroline's husband, and Everett and Skyler's father.

Quote: *"Have you been to Amelia's horrid Christmas room yet? A candy-colored nightmare. I think she collected all that tacky crap in an effort to somehow own the idea of Christmas, to dominate it."*

Mother Hawthorne, the grandmother

Ancient. Blind in one eye. Buried in furs. Mother Hawthorne is Amelia's grandmother. No one remembers her real first name, and no one knows exactly how old she is. She has managed to outlast a whole generation of Hawthornes one branch below her on the family tree. She rarely speaks and can barely get around on her own. It would have been impossible for her to strangle Amelia. Mother Hawthorne is the grandmother of Thomas and Jimmy.

Quote: "..."

Quote (only to a Maven with **The Pallid Mask** marked): *"I have looked into the gloaming eyes of Death many times now, and each time I have told that pallid harbinger, 'No! Not today. Today is not the day I take your bony hand in mine and walk to that shadowy realm beyond the Black Gate.' You can do that, too, my dear. You can fix your gaze upon the Reaper and decline his cold affections. The more interesting question is 'Why do it?' Why should I want to keep living in this frail body, barely seen to by kin who no longer remember my name? Why should I want to keep silently tittering in my husk? Because I want to see the looks upon their faces when they realize it's all coming to an end."*

Locations

The Chestnut room

The stale, nutty smell of dog biscuits. Chestnut IV sitting on a silky pouf, holding court. A tiny Christmas tree decorated with dog bone ornaments.

Paint the Scene: *The front room of Amelia's house is a temple dedicated to Chestnuts III. What do you see that shows how much Amelia loved her precious Pekignese dogs?*

Amelia's bedroom

Floral prints and Tiffany lampshades. A vintage dress form in one corner. A loaded bar cart, untouched.

Paint the Scene: *What do you see in Amelia's bedroom that indicates she had a much softer heart than her public persona would have you believe?*

The dining room

A table that seats twelve. A curio filled with Hummel figurines. A loaded bar cart, untouched.

Paint the Scene: *What do you see in the grand dining room that shows just how lonely Amelia truly was?*

The Christmas room

A sensor is triggered and a recorded voice bellows out: "Ho, ho, ho! M-e-e-erry Christmas!" A model train chugs along an enormous track that spans the room. The smell of balsam.

Paint the Scene: *This room is decorated for Christmas year-round. Does the room feel warm and inviting to you or does it feel oppressive to you? Something else? What do you see that reinforces how you feel?*

The kitchen

An enormous island for preparing food. Stainless steel and marble on every surface. The thrum of Chestnut IV's automatic feeder.

Paint the Scene: *How do you know Amelia (and the other Hawthornes) have never used this space to cook a meal?*

Void Clues

- ☐ Magdalena's tarot deck is just The Devil, one after the other.
- ☐ A nativity scene features a Baby Jesus that suddenly bleats like a goat.
- ☐ A thick, tar-like substance begins oozing out of all the nutcrackers' eyes.
- ☐ Chestnut IV is whispering to an unseen entity in the corner of the room.
- ☐ An advent calendar, behind each door of which is an occult symbol or picture of someone who was brutally murdered in Brindlewood Bay.
- ☐ Evidence that Amelia is a member of the Midwives of the Fragrant Void (only if Layer Three of the Dark Conspiracy is unlocked).

Clues

- ☐ A shattered eggnog glass.
- ☐ A bundle of racy Christmas cards.
- ☐ A secret crawlspace.
- ☐ A suicide note from years ago, preserved as a keepsake.
- ☐ A stack of unpaid bills.
- ☐ A parody version of "The Twelve Days of Christmas," the lyrics of which are a scathing indictment of the Hawthorne family.
- ☐ A bottle of pills that has been tampered with.
- ☐ An argument between Amelia and her lawyers.
- ☐ A slip and fall accident that went unreported.
- ☐ A Christmas tree ornament that mocks a Suspect.
- ☐ Droplets of dried blood in a strange place.
- ☐ An old yearbook from Amelia, Thomas, and Jimmy's high school days.
- ☐ Amelia's rejection of a Suspect's request for money.
- ☐ A security camera hidden in a papier mache statue of Frosty the Snowman.
- ☐ A stack of old board games, each missing a pawn of a particular color.
- ☐ A Hawthorne family portrait with one person carefully cut out of it.
- ☐ Amelia's parents' will, leaving her nearly everything and cutting out Thomas.
- ☐ A plane ticket to Rio de Janeiro.
- ☐ A Christmas wreath festooned with poison oak, nightshade, and holly.
- ☐ An extravagant gift for Chestnut IV.

A Murder Most Mucky

Presenting the Mystery

Complexity: 8

Note: *The tiny village of Mucky Point is a dangerous place, loaded with hints of the strange and supernatural. Only play this mystery if Layer 4 of the Dark Conspiracy is unlocked.*

Present this mystery at the top floor of The Candlelight Booksellers, during the weekly meeting of the Murder Mavens mystery book club.

Paint the Scene: *As the camera pans around the loft where you hold your Murder Mavens meetings, what do we see that shows how this is one of the coziest spots in all of Brindlewood Bay?*

After the meeting, the Mavens are approached by Janet Flock, owner of the bookstore. Janet shows them a story in the local paper, about a Mucky Point lighthouse keeper, Cyrus Creel, who died after falling off the little walkway just outside the lighthouse's lantern room. The article quotes several locals who think Mr. Creel was murdered, as the grizzled old lighthouse keeper had kept the lantern lit for decades and only someone green would lose their footing and tumble to their death. The paper also quotes the Mucky Point constable, Alvin Deschain, who says the death was strictly an accident and any talk of murder is baseless speculation.

Janet reminds the Mavens that Mucky Point is only a few miles up the road, and suggests that Constable Deschain might appreciate their unique insight into the case. If the Mavens press Janet for why she is so interested in the case, she will reveal that Cyrus was an old family friend, and that it would put her at ease knowing—definitively—there was no foul play involved in his death.

Mucky Point is a tiny hamlet in Brindlewood County. It has existed to support the operation of the lighthouse for most of its history, but in recent decades, as the lighthouse has become less and less important to maritime navigation, it has shrunk to just a few small homes and businesses. In Brindlewood Bay, Mucky Point has a reputation for being a shriveled little place, isolated and unfriendly to outsiders. In Mucky Point, folks from Brindlewood Bay are viewed with some animosity, espe-

cially after the Mucky Point lighthouse never took off as a tourist attraction, in part because of interference from Brindlewood Bay's tourism board.

As the Mavens arrive in Mucky Point, give them a quick lay of the land:

- To the east, on a raised, rocky area, is the lighthouse.
- Near the base of the lighthouse is a small shack used by the lighthouse keepers as storage and lodging.
- Mucky Point proper consists of a single thoroughfare, along which can be found: The Golden Bull Roadhouse, Deschain's Gas & Sundries, The Mucky Point Lighthouse Museum, and Codswallop's Bait & Tackle.

Establishing Question: *Mucky Pointers are rumored to have a strange physical characteristic they all share. What have you heard?*

Moments

- A group of hardened men and women, leering... suspicious.
- An old song you don't recognize, the singer's voice halting and uneven, playing on a jukebox. The label identifying the song is blackened out.
- The sound of wailing in the distance—a woman crying out in anguish?—that turns out to just be the wind.
- A wall with exposed brick that is soft and slushy, like cold mud.
- The remains of a shredded Union Jack tied to a fence post, strips of cloth flapping in the wind.
- An old man with the "Mucky Point look" warns you to go back to Brindlewood Bay, where it's safe.

Suspects

Alvin Deschain, the constable

Lanky. Slightly hunched back. Messy uniform. Alvin has lived in Mucky Point all his life. He is suspicious of outsiders, even those from places as close as Brindlewood Bay.

Quote: *"There's no way Cyrus was murdered. It simply wouldn't happen in Mucky Point. We're a close-knit community—we care for each other—but I suppose someone like you wouldn't understand something like that, would you?"*

Tara Hill, a tavern keeper

Husky. Mullet. Sleeves rolled up. Tara moved to Mucky Point ten years ago when she inherited The Golden Bull Roadhouse from her uncle, Milton Hill. Her wife, Sandy Hill (née Deschain), was born and raised in Mucky Point, and is the only reason she doesn't feel like a complete outsider.

Quote: *"Mucky Pointers are a special breed. Have you talked to Thurgood yet? No? Well, if you do, make sure you don't catch him in the middle of one of his... spells. You might regret it."*

Sandy Hill, a tavern keeper

Ruddy-cheeked. Pile of red hair. Messy apron. Sandy has lived in Mucky Point all her life. She almost got out before she met Tara. They fell in love ten years ago, got married, and have been running The Golden Bull together ever since. She is Marvin's daughter and Alvin's niece.

Quote: *"Cyrus Creel was a hateful old bastard. He hated everyone and everything—everything except that damn lighthouse. You know, the county tried to tear it down last year—to make room for new development—but he and Eleanor managed to stop them. Those two lobbied hard to have it designated an 'historical landmark.' And let me tell you: they made a lot of enemies during that fight."*

George Codswallop, the store owner

High-pitched, whistle-y voice. Limps. Pronounced physical characteristics from the Establishing Question. George is a middle-aged man who has worked in the Bait & Tackle all his adult life. If Mucky Pointers are generally suspicious of outsiders, George is downright hostile.

Quote: *"Unless you plan on buying a bucket of worms, I don't have anything to say to you!"*

A Murder Most Mucky

Eleanor Hurley, the historian

Costume jewelry. Streak of gray. Colorful scarf. Eleanor runs the newly-established Mucky Point Lighthouse Museum, carefully tending to the books and antique lighthouse equipment that make up the museum's modest collection. She was in love with Cyrus, and, if pressed, will admit to having had a long-term romantic relationship with him.

Quote: *"There are all sorts of fascinating things about the lighthouse that very few people are even aware of. For example: the base of the thing predates the lighthouse structure by some 300 years, and is made of a strange, black stone I haven't seen anywhere else in this area. I've been trying to get geologists to come take a look at it for years, but for some reason they always back out at the last minute."*

Thurgood Codswallop, a fisherman

Pitch-black eyes. Extremely small teeth. Pronounced physical characteristics from the Establishing Question. Thurgood is nearly as hostile to outsiders as his brother George is. Thurgood is sometimes found sitting in his little boat, staring out to sea, feverishly whispering strange, unintelligible words to himself.

Quote: *"I have frequently seen the sea in my dreams. She calls to me. She calls to all of us. She wants us to return to Her, to the icy womb from which we all crawled. I guess that's why I chose the line of work that I did. It keeps me close to Her."*

Stephen Blair, a lighthouse keeper

Handsome. Thoughtful. Well-pressed uniform. Stephen grew up in Brindlewood Bay, and moved to Mucky Point last year when he got the job as Assistant Lighthouse Keeper. Most people will tell you that Cyrus was openly abusive to the young man, but Stephen will laugh it off, claiming that the old lighthouse keeper was simply "complicated." If pressed, Stephen will share stories about some of the strange events he has witnessed over the last few months (reveal a Void Clue).

Quote: *"I suppose it's kind of strange for someone from my generation to want to be a lighthouse keeper. But I've always been fascinated by this lighthouse in particular, and there was no way in heck I was going to keep working at my parents' bakery in Brindlewood Bay."*

Benny "Tug" Williams, a drunk

Red-nosed. Slurred speech. Partially untucked plaid shirt. Tug spends most of his time at The Golden Bull and is rarely sober. Because no one takes him too seriously, he's been able to observe a lot of the goings-on in Mucky Point, and is a good source of information—if the Mavens can keep him lucid, that is.

Quote: *"I've seen some dark and terrible things in Mucky Point—things that would make you go white as a sheet if you saw 'em. 'Course, no one listens to me—no one ever listens to a drunk."*

Marvin Deschain, the gas station attendant

Haggard. Flint-eyed. Greasy overalls. Marvin owns and operates Deschain's Gas & Sundries with his brother, Alvin. He was best friends with Cyrus growing up, but had grown distant from him in recent years. He is Sandy's father.

Quote: *"Cyrus was a tough old gizzard, and nimbler than a monkey when it came to getting around that lighthouse. There's no way in Hell he slipped and fell—I don't care what my brother says. Someone killed him. And you know what? The S.O.B. probably deserved it!"*

Genevieve Deschain, the mayor

Shiny coat. Good teeth. "Mayor" medallion on her collar. Genevieve is a golden retriever that belongs to the Deschain brothers. The town elected her mayor a few years ago in an attempt to gin up some publicity. Most days she can be found at the end of the pier, staring out to sea, occasionally barking at phantoms only she can see.

Special Rule: *If a Maven with The Chariot marked approaches Genevieve, the dog will befriend her and lead her to a Clue.*

Locations

The lighthouse

The sensation of your stomach dropping, like when you go down a hill on a rollercoaster, as soon as you step through the entrance. There are no echoes here, despite being a hollow stone cylinder. No matter how loud you speak, it's always a whisper.

Paint the Scene: *What evidence here suggests the lighthouse keepers through the years have had... strange beliefs?*

The lighthouse keepers' shack

A pair of small but cozy looking beds. Two large sea chests and a tall wardrobe. A small, plain dining table.

Paint the Scene: *In 1932, one of the lighthouse keepers savagely murdered the other. What do you see here, even today, that is a reminder of this grim history?*

The Golden Bull Roadhouse

Dimly lit. The smell of beer and cheap fried food. A fan spins lazily overhead in the Summer.

Paint the Scene: *The Golden Bull was originally a lodge for a group of spiritualists in the 1920s. What did they leave behind?*

Deschain's Gas & Sundries

A wall of cigarettes behind the counter. Gas station snacks: Corn Nibs, Meat Whips, and Snuckers, plus a few imported treats, like Bumblecracks and Nob Noms. A DrinkPlus-branded refrigerator case ("It's a soft drink PLUS so much more!").

Paint the Scene: *The Deschains are the oldest family in Mucky Point. What here is a reminder of that?*

The Mucky Point Lighthouse Museum

Extremely small. Smells of furniture polish. Floors made of wood reclaimed from shipwrecks.

Paint the Scene: *Looking around, you can tell this building was originally used for another, darker purpose. What do you see?*

Codswallop's Bait & Tackle

A distinct smell: fish, blood, and bile. Very poorly lit. Every step is like being stroked on the back of your hand by something oily.

Paint the Scene (for Mavens who have marked **The Pallid Mask**): *You are able to see something here from the "other side." What is it?*

Paint the Scene (for everyone else): *Why does this place give you the creeps?*

Void Clues

- ☐ A local's wild-eyed ravings about the existence of mermaids and selkies in the waters off Mucky Point.
- ☐ A pile of dead seagulls, with one living seagull standing atop it, preening.
- ☐ A prayer to King Poseidon, followed by a baleful, dissonant song.
- ☐ Mermaid dreams, terrifying and erotic.
- ☐ A small, half-decayed biped, caught in a crab pot. It appears... human-ish?
- ☐ A circle of lamplit rowboats at night, a few hundred yards out to sea. The rowers are standing up in the boats, loudly singing the praises of Hecate, Persephone, Athena, and other goddesses.

Notes

[illegible]

Exit Stage Death

Presenting the Mystery

Complexity: 8

Note: *This mystery revolves around The Court of the Occluded King, a cult that is rival to The Midwives of the Fragrant Void. Many aspects of the mystery don't come into play unless certain Maven characteristics or Dark Conspiracy elements are unlocked. The mystery can still be enjoyed without those elements in play—it will come across to the players as cryptic and weird, if not immediately relevant to the happenings in Brindlewood Bay—but it's something to be mindful of before choosing to run it.*

The Mavens are enjoying a week of sightseeing and cultural activities in Boston. They're taking in a show on the last night of their tour, a strange and disturbing production at The Twilight Playhouse called *The King in Shadows*. Normally, they'd skip something so avant-garde, but one of the Mavens has a nephew connected to the production.

Establishing Question: *Whose nephew is connected to the show? What's his name, and what's his involvement in the production?*

The play is divided into three acts. Act One is somewhat normal and depicts the day-to-day life of a female protagonist, identified as the Journeywoman. The first act ends when the Journeywoman receives news that her three immediate family members—mother, father, and brother—have all been killed in a bizarre fishing accident.

Act Two is considerably stranger, and depicts the Journeywoman's travels in the underworld with a character called the Boatman as they seek to find the court of the Occluded King in order to petition him for the release of her family members from his shadowy realm.

Act Three is utterly bizarre, difficult to follow, and, to large portions of the audience that walked out in the middle of it, insufferable. The bulk of this act involves the introduction of three courtiers of the Occluded King: the Duchess, the Prince, and the Knave.

Assign each courtier to a player and ask them to describe the scene in which the character is introduced in the play. The scene should be either horrifying or bizarre. If any of the Mavens has **A Shadow in the Garden** marked, you may also reveal a Void Clue during one of these scenes.

The play concludes with the appearance of the Occluded King, an overly tall figure in tattered black robes, a ghost-white mask, and a blood-red helm. If any of the Mavens has **The Pallid Mask** marked, they trigger the Prophecy of the King move, below.

The Prophecy of the King

When you have the Pallid Mask marked when the Occluded King appears on stage, he calls you "Most Beloved" and whispers a prophecy of death to you (you are the only one who can hear the whispering). This prophecy relates to when another Maven will die. In a future scene, when another Maven is getting ready to take an action that will require a die roll, you can say, "This is it! This is what the Occluded King whispered to me about! This is how you're going to die!" If they go through with the action anyway, you both mark XP. On the die roll, the 6- result is replaced with: "You are killed; the Keeper will describe how."

The chorus members sing a shrieking, discordant dirge as the courtiers push the Journeywoman toward the King. The lights go out, and when they come back on again, the curtain has been lowered. No one takes a bow and there are no ovations; very few people even clap. The ushers then help people exit the theater.

The next morning, as the Mavens are getting ready to head back to Brindlewood Bay, the nephew character drops by the hotel room and nervously explains that Natassia Gray, the young actress who played the Journeywoman, was found dead at the end of last night's performance, a ritual dagger plunged into her heart while the lights were out. Boston PD is investigating, but he hopes the Mavens might also get involved. He explains that the only people who were close enough to Natassia when it happened were the actors, chorus members, and director (if you wish, you can identify each Suspect by name at this point). The nephew might also be a Suspect, depending on how the Establishing Question was answered, and so clearing his name would be another reason for the Mavens to get involved.

If the Mavens take the case, the nephew character will explain that *The King in Shadows* cast hangs out at a drinking club, The Styx, during the day. He will also tell them that the cast is having dinner at the apartment of Ambrose and Veruca Sinclair that night.

Moments

- Stagehands calling back and forth to one another, rolling set pieces around, laughing and talking.
- The stage curtain, red in most venues, is deep blue—almost black—with a constellation of tiny stars embroidered on it.
- A counterweight comes crashing down, narrowly missing you.
- A barman, completely silent, answers your questions with raised eyebrows and careful gestures.
- A miniature river flowing into a miniature cave.
- Props loom overhead like dark sentinels.

Suspects

All of the Suspects are members of The Court of the Occluded King, a death cult that aims to eventually thin the Veil Between Worlds enough for their shadowy lord to enter this world and claim it for his own. Each performance of *The King in Shadows* is a ritual that gets them one step closer to achieving this aim. Despite their unsavory beliefs, the murder of Natassia Gray is a shock to the group, and none of them wants to be arrested and charged for the crime.

The Suspects will not willingly discuss The Court of the Occluded King or their membership in it, preferring instead to be seen merely as members of an eccentric theater troupe. However, if Layer Three of the Dark Conspiracy is unlocked, they are more open about their affiliation and aims. If the Mavens ever mention the Midwives of the Fragrant Void directly, the Suspects will explain that they stand in cosmic opposition to the Midwives, and may even drop hints about what that cult is up to in Brindlewood Bay.

If Layer Four of the Dark Conspiracy is unlocked, one or more Suspects may offer to help the Mavens defend themselves against the Midwives by teaching them a magical ward that prevents Sendings and Servitors from entering a space. This teaching can be the basis of an Occult Move roll, which is made with advantage.

Exit Stage Death

A note about roleplaying The Court of the Occluded King: no matter what, play these Suspects seriously, even though their presence in the story may come across as slightly comic or absurd. The desired effect is like what you find in the film What We Do in the Shadows—characters that are amusing, but grounded in the truth and darkness of their world.

Ambrose Sinclair, the director

Frizzy, gray hair. Penetrating gaze. Constantly fidgeting with a pair of Baoding balls. Ambrose is very upset about Natassia's death; he viewed her as a protégé and a rising star in the world of experimental theater. Ambrose is Veruca's husband.

Quote: *"Staging The King in Shadows will be my greatest work—what the world will remember me for. Did you know the author of the play is unknown? In fact, there may not even be an author. It could be that the play merely... exists, like an indelible truth of the universe."*

Veruca Sinclair, the Duchess

Shiny black hair, pulled back tight. Blood red lipstick. The smell of tomato vine. Veruca is heartbroken about Natassia, who she treated like a daughter. Veruca is Ambrose's wife.

Quote: *"Oh, Dis Pater, I would never be so foolish as to begrudge you taking what is rightfully yours, but why would you take our Natassia from us now? She was so young, Father of Night—surely she still had work to accomplish for you in this world?"*

Antony Veit, the Boatman

Barrel-chested. Great, bushy beard. Easy, thunderous laugh. Antony is the most immediately friendly and approachable member of the theater troupe. Whereas most of the others are content to dress in dark clothing and skulk about in the shadows, Antony is something of a bon vivant. He is Belladonna's husband.

Quote: *"This is the best job I ever had in my life! Before I met Belladonna, I was a stevedore—up at the crack of dawn, long hours, backbreaking work. Now? I sleep in until 10, get up and have brunch with Bella, and then head to The Twilight to get ready for the matinee. Sure, the people putting on this show are a little... unusual. But aren't we all?"*

Belladonna Veit, a chorus member

Dark, wispy clothing. Pale skin. Tattoos. Belladonna seems least bothered by Natassia's death and, if pressed, will say that she's going to audition for the role of the Journeywoman now that Natassia is out of the way. Belladonna is Antony's wife.

Quote: *"Of course, I should have been cast as the Journeywoman in the first place. No one is more intimately familiar with the words of our lord—I mean, the play—than I am. But Ambrose wouldn't hear of it. It was always 'Natassia, Natassia, Natassia! She's a star! She's the future of this brave new world we are creating!'"*

Gregor Thune, the Occluded King

Vacant eyes. Thin, almost transparent flesh. Mostly unresponsive. Gregor Thune hasn't been the same since taking on the role of the Occluded King. He used to be a dynamic, energetic member of the troupe, but now only occasionally breaks his silence to mutter a few cryptic words. He is Giancarla's husband.

Quote: *"...down below, in the vastness... gems and gold a-glittering... unspeakable wealth... unknowable knowledge... he is reaching out for us... calling us home to him... would that we could return to the cold embrace of the Void... but the Void has rejected us... and now we are truly alone... down below... down below... the inky vastness down below..."*

Giancarla Thune, a chorus member

Long hair with gray roots. Flower crown. Sweet disposition. Giancarla has been friends with Ambrose and Veruca for a long time. It used to be that she, husband Gregor, and the Sinclairs were inseparable, but things have changed ever since Gregor took on the role of the Occluded King and became so... empty. Now she just sings in the chorus and takes care of Gregor. Giancarla is very familiar with Brindlewood Bay and the town's history.

Quote: *"You're from Brindlewood Bay? I know it well—my brother-in-law lives there. Do you know him? He's a banker, very uptight. He disapproves of these theater-types Gregor and I hang out with, let me tell you... Oh! I hope you're not as stuck-up as he is. Please tell me you're not!"*

Otho Fane, the Knave

Luxuriantly obese. Fond of cravats. Smells of lilac and baby powder. Otho is part of the Boston nouveau-riche, having made all his money investing wisely in tech and medical stocks. He joined this troupe out of sheer boredom, and was delighted to discover that the Sinclairs had landed on something truly exciting—truly groundbreaking—in *The King in Shadows*. He is Delia's husband.

Quote: *"Ambrose is a visionary, of course—how else do you explain a production that is so brave, so exciting, so... thoroughly ahead of its time? You can't, of course. Genius always defies explanation. But I'm very happy to be here, very happy to be a part of this terrific work. I get chills when I think about it, frankly."*

Delia Fane, a chorus member

Spritely. Modern coiffeur. Trying hard to fit in. Delia doesn't understand *The King in Shadows*. The play—and the activities surrounding it—are a complete black box for her. She mostly wants to make her husband Otho happy and not be an embarrassment in front of the other troupe members. She was a hesitant understudy for Natassia.

Quote: *"Poor Natassia—I'm told she was very good in the role of the Journeywoman. Of course, I've seen her play the part up close a dozen times, but The King in Shadows is hopelessly opaque, and so I don't really know what counts as good and what doesn't. Ambrose and Veruca thought she was great, and Otho assures me she was brilliant, but the role doesn't even have any lines until about thirty minutes in, and the whole second act was just her and Antony rowing an imaginary boat with imaginary oars down an imaginary river, occasionally punctuated by wailing from the chorus. I mean, Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf? it is not."*

Maxime Gray, the Prince

Handsome. Fresh-faced. Black turtleneck. Maxime is distraught over the death of his young wife, Natassia. They were genuinely in love, and he will happily share details of how they met on the set of Ambrose's last play, how they fell in love, and how they were married by Veruca at a lovely, private ceremony at The Styx.

Quote: *"Maybe it would be best if the Occluded King really did come into this world and establish dominion over us. Living in his murky, shadowy realm has to be better than dealing with this emptiness in my heart."*

Exit Stage Death

Locations

The set

Looming shadows—some painted, some real. Noticeably colder than the rest of the theater. You feel alone, no matter how many others are on stage.

Paint the Scene: *What do you see that subtly suggests this is some sort of ritual space?*

The catwalk

Narrow walkways. Ropes, pulleys, and lights. The best view of the front and back of the house.

Paint the Scene: *This area has been the site of more than one romantic encounter between the people who work at the Twilight Playhouse. What do you see that confirms this?*

Backstage

Busy people. Napping people. Vacant people.

Paint the Scene: *Do you have any experience in the theater? If so, what about this place takes you back?*

The dressing room

Mirrors framed in light. The smell of makeup and grease paint, and sweaty bodies. Stockings draped here and there.

Paint the Scene: *These actors may be dedicated to the Occluded King in more ways than just performing in a play about him. How do you know this?*

The Styx

Day glo murals. Licorice smell. “Venus” by Bananarama playing on the jukebox.

Paint the Scene: *Being in The Styx feels like being unstuck in time. What do you experience that makes you feel that way?*

The Sinclairs’ apartment

Sunken living room. A fish bowl with a single set of keys in it. Mid Century modern furniture.

Paint the Scene: *What do you see in the apartment that hints at Ambrose and Veruca’s fascination with death?*

Clues

- ☐ A group text message wherein Natassia expresses doubt about the direction Ambrose is taking the play in.
- ☐ A diary entry indicates Maxime wasn’t really in love with Natassia, and that he married her because the Sinclairs pressured him to.
- ☐ A ritual dagger identical to the one used to stab Natassia.
- ☐ A life insurance policy taken out on Natassia.
- ☐ A script with the words “I’m going to KILL YOU!” written in a margin.
- ☐ A stash of love letters in an unusual place.
- ☐ A book, *Mysteries of the Occluded King*, which features an illustration of the King’s lover that looks uncannily similar to a Suspect.
- ☐ A pile of bones, hidden.
- ☐ A secret message from a Hollywood talent agency to Natassia.
- ☐ A shattered Britty award.
- ☐ A secret two-way mirror.
- ☐ A paternity test proving Natassia was a male Suspect’s secret daughter.
- ☐ A prophecy written in a dream journal indicating Natassia must be sacrificed.
- ☐ A large amount of powerful sedatives.
- ☐ A spell, clumsily cast.
- ☐ Evidence of sympathetic magic being used on a Suspect (pick one: poppet/lock of hair/salt trail/egg in a strange place/something else).
- ☐ A costume lined with arsenic.
- ☐ A depiction of the Erinyes in a provocative place.
- ☐ Risqué photos of a Suspect.
- ☐ A bus ticket out of Boston, recently purchased.

Void Clues

- ☐ Dozens of people in the audience put on golden masks and begin making mocking, animal-like noises at the stage. None will remember doing this.
- ☐ There is nothing in the night sky—no stars, no moon, no clouds—just inky blackness.
- ☐ Random people on the streets are wearing featureless gold masks.
- ☐ Every page in every book features the same picture of a Suspect.
- ☐ A brother and sister with no eyes in their sockets are entertaining each other while waiting for their parents.
- ☐ A driftwood crown dripping with blood and bits of meat is waiting for the Mavens somewhere.

Notes
